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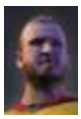

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Unplugged: GenCon Indianapolis 2006 - Day 1, Thursday (part II)

by Dr. Matt Carlson
August 21, 2006

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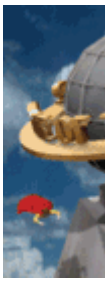
You've got videogames in my boardgame convention! – D&D Online, Ryzom Ring and more

Unplugged

How inconsiderate of Turbine to miss my appointment! They weren't there when I showed up, and the folks in the booth had no clue where they had walked off to... Well, it was no big deal, so I scheduled another appointment for Friday morning, and began to wander off – when I realized I had confused my appointments.

I took a brisk walk over to the **Dream Authentics** booth and tried my hand at their old-school upright consoles. For several thousand dollars, you too can own a decently powered PC hooked up to a quality monitor and loaded into an upright arcade machine – complete with all the trackballs, joysticks, and other buttons you might want. Playing a game of **Centipede** with a nice trackball was a treat and I thought about building my own, there are designs out there on the net, after all. However, I realized the chances of me building one from scratch are pretty small, and with the 180 licensed games thrown into the bargain the price point isn't such a bad deal. Of course, the real interest is in all the options. In addition to joystick, button, and trackball placement, they also offer custom variations of each type. A nearly all-green button and joystick setup is just what I would want. You can even have multiple different setups if you want to play with a lightgun and/or steering wheel. I clearly would not want to leave off a good spin knob for playing Circus or Tempest. Other options



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This Week In Games

Unplugged
Dr. Matt Carlson talks board games.

include custom decals for the exterior, and the obligatory coin slots if you prefer. They even own the licensing to put up decals of your favorite old-school game. If PC gaming isn't your thing, other gaming consoles could be installed inside, as demonstrated by the Guitar Hero console also displayed at the booth.

After a brief (well, not too brief, classic video games and I go way back) playing of Centipede (I set the high score of course) I headed back to **Turbine** to talk about **Atari** and the new updates to **Dungeons and Dragons Online**. I have to admit that I played the original release of the game for awhile before becoming a bit bored with it, finding the leveling to slow down significantly unless I was able to find a good group – which was not always easy. Things have improved over the summer and even more things are coming down the pike for the fall. There have been several updates, all of which are free to subscribers to download. There will be a 'gold edition' of some sort coming along, which is simply a new edition box that will also contain all the freely-downloadable new content so that newcomers won't have to spend hours downloading and patching when they first log on. In July a new Drow race was added to the game, which players can unlock for use if they perform specific in-game quests. August saw an update introducing significant new undead challenges and other content as well as solo dungeons. Previously, dungeons often required a party to enter and successfully complete. Solo mode is a new difficulty category, and can be played by a character who is just killing time while waiting for a group more appropriate to their level to form up. The big news is the upcoming fall update. It will increase the maximum level cap from 10 to 12 (which is greater than it sounds, as each level has several sub-levels), a player auction house of some type, and also include PvP (player vs player combat) in two forms. The first is a free-for-all fight pit arena found in taverns. Any player hopping into the pit is fair game for any other player in the pit. There will also be team matchmaking in some sort of tournament style that attempts to match up teams of similar level and composition. At present, there are no firm plans for a purchasable upgrade to the game, but with the regular content upgrades, that may not be anything very necessary.

While I actually moved on after talking D&D Online, let us jump forward in time to Friday morning, so that I can include all my D&D/Atari information in one location. The two final games I viewed were **D&D Tactics** for the Sony PSP expected in February of 2007, and **NeverWinter Nights 2** for the PC. I'll save my favorite for last and start with D&D Tactics. D&D Tactics is a strategy role-playing game where a player controls up to six characters in a party and proceeds to fight through a dungeon using a turn-based system of combat. There is a veneer of storyline to the game, but the focus is on character leveling and combat. Thankfully the game can be saved at almost any time, allowing players to pick up and put down the game on the go. Wireless multiplayer is included and the story can be played cooperatively or players can take their characters and match

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them up against each other in a PvP brawl. In addition to all the standard, expected characters, the game includes psionic characters and their associated basic and prestige classes. While the emphasis is on combat, the backstory does allow players to choose between some tough decisions within the game. As is growing more common with the better RPGs available, player's decisions will definitely affect their alignment and subsequent events within the game world. Next, I got to see some action on the Neverwinter Nights 2 front (NWN 2).

I'm a huge fan of the first game (Neverwinter Nights), primarily as a player. I would sit back and let the online community build pretty good scenarios that I and my friends would then log into and play for our own enjoyment. The basic idea is a game engine that allows people to build their own adventures with dialogue hooks, plot items, and all sorts of other bells and whistles. Once a scenario is constructed, the game will take care of the rules, and players can use that scenario to play through a game. If desired, a player can even take on the role of a Dungeon Master (DM) and hold ultimate power over the game to create new situations on the fly or adjust things dynamically. The new game expands on previous capabilities in several directions. First, the graphics and building tools have been improved. Not in leaps in bounds, but definitely detectible ways. The graphics are more detailed and richer, more up to par with average 2006 titles. One nice new feature is the ability to mix tile sets. There are several special 'door' tiles provided that help bridge the gap between various tile sets, allowing a snowy field to seamlessly lead into a dungeon or a cave turn into a city sewer without having to move the characters into a new map area. Items placed into scenarios are presented with finer resolution of control. A simple column can be scaled to impressive size, or even just fattened and then cut off

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(shortened) in order to present the huge, but short columns – such as one might find supporting a huge structure overhead. Items, (and even creatures if I recall correctly), can be tinted to add an endless supply of variation to the many possibilities for encounters. The game rules are the newest 3.5 version of D&D and even include most sub-races such as tieflings as well as a wealth of new classes. Players are also now allowed to directly control their non-player companions rather than just offer suggestions as in the past. The final thing of note would be the large effort put into making cut-scenes easier to create. As demonstrated in the adventure provided with the game, cut scenes can now be scripted with dialogue, text, and effects to provide a more cinematic feel for those module creators who want to go the extra mile. The game comes out in October 2006, so I fully expect those people reading this to go out and purchase a copy and make me some killer modules that I can then download and play. I promise I'll have fun!

My last meeting of the day was with Milko Berset from the French company **Nevrax**, makers of the online massively multiplayer online role playing game (MMORPG) entitled **Ryzom**. Never heard of it? Well, it unfortunately launched about the same time as another popular title, **World of Warcraft** and didn't get quite the press coverage that a **Blizzard** title might. Not to be outdone, they continued with **Ryzom** and went back to the drawing boards to produce **Ryzom Ring**. Many years ago, some of the first multiplayer online games were text based games called MUDs (or multi-user dungeons). After a player had earned enough respect, they would often be allowed to build and expand the MUD they played on by creating new content. Ryzom Ring is that same idea pushed onto a much larger canvas. Essentially, **Ryzom Ring** is arguably the first MMORPG that allows players to create new content. Graphically, the game is quite beautiful. The landscape and creatures have a surreal/different sort of look that one might expect in a European RPG (it reminds me of The Fifth Element in that it is beautiful, but also subtly different than what American audiences might be accustomed to...) The graphics side of the online game was the most impressive, able to display and show hundreds of unique players or NPCs at the same time without any lag. Once the graphics were suitably impressive, I was treated to a scenario that M. Berset constructed in almost an hour. (Compare that to an average user trying to use normal development tools, which might take a week or two.) The user interface for creating modules is a simple drag and drop method. Initially, a preset map is selected, and then starting zones are placed for the player characters. Then terrain items such as trees, objects such as chests or doors, or creatures can be placed. Creatures (or characters) can easily be grouped together under the heading of a leader. Any commands scripted for a leader, such as patrolling, guarding, etc... will also be applied to the rest of the group. Trigger areas, patrol routes, and other types of scripting actions remain drag-and-drop after placement and can be adjusted on the fly in the game window or on the overhead map. Scripting basic quests is a matter of clicking on dialogue

boxes which create a list of default events that can also be used to trigger further actions. On the whole, it looked as if the scripting tools were quite powerful but remained fairly user friendly. Finished zones (or modules) can then be played by other players whenever their creator is online. The zones are played on the Ryzom servers, not hosted on a player's computer, but the creator must be online in order for others to play. Zones can be locked so only specific people may enter or may be open to all. Creators are even allowed to enter into a creator (GM) mode where they can affect or even take direct control of the various non-player creatures present. All player-created zones are also ranked by those who have tried them out, giving excellent feedback to any future prospective players.

I might hesitate to suggest to readers yet another MMORPG, but the game is entirely free to try for an indefinite length of time. Players who wish to try out the game can download the client for free and play up to limited level. To advance past that level, one needs to pay for a subscription. However, when the **Ryzom Ring** tools are released, they will also be free to download and try out. Without a subscription, the available creatures remain at that same lower level, but players and even creators can continue to play and create for as long as they wish. This might be just the thing for a family where one person can create an adventure for several others to play on their own free accounts... the only restriction remains in the level limit. With a lack of an initial investment required to try the game out, I would encourage anyone interested to give it a whirl when the construction tools are released later in early September 2006.

With my last interview running slightly long, I dashed off to meet friends at a nonexistent Indian restaurant (we ate somewhere else) and I headed home to rest up for my next adventure at... GENCON 2006!

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